The Last Days of Judas Iscariot

By Stephen Adly Guirgis

JUDGE: **(Pg 8-9)** Next case!

GLORIA: Between heaven and hell – there is another place. This place: Hope. Hope – is located right over here in downtown Purgatory.

JUDGE: Next case, Bailiff!

GLORIA: Now, Purgatory, contrary to popular belief, has plumbing and bodegas, and they even got a movie theater and a little park that people can walk their dogs at. Hope – well, it ain't got none a that, and it definitely don't smell good.

JUDGE: Next case!!

GLORIA: Now Hope, it changes with the times, but has stood always as God's gift to the last of his children. In Biblical times, Hope was an oasis in the desert. In medieval days, a shack free of plague. Today, Hope is no longer a place for contemplation – "litigation" being the preferred new order of the day.

JUDGE: Where's my damn bailiff?!

BAILIFF: Here, sir

JUDGE: Then call the next damn case!!!

BAILIFF: Yes, sir. God and the Kingdom of Heaven and Earth versus Thorseen the Implacable: motion to appeal!

JUDGE: Denied – Next case!

BAILIFF: God and the Kingdom of Heaven and Earth versus Benedict Arnold –

JUDGE: Aw, hell no!

BAILIFF: God and the Kingdom of Heaven and Earth versus Judas Iscariot –

JUDGE: -- Judas Iscariot?! Who brings this crap before me?!

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INTRODUCTION

From the moment he planted a kiss on Jesus of Nazareth in the Garden of Gethsemane, Judas Iscariot sealed his own fate: To be remembered as history's most famous traitor. But by identifying Jesus to the Jewish authorities, Judas set into motion the series of events that became the foundations of the Christian faith: Jesus's arrest, his trial, his crucifixion, and eventually his resurrection.

Given how little we actually know about him from the Bible, Judas Iscariot remains one of its most enigmatic figures. In recent years, the discovery of the long-lost Gospel of Juda, has led some scholars to reconsider his role, and even to ask whether he might have been unfairly blamed for betraying Jesus.

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PROSECUTING ATTORNEY: **(Pg 34)** Prosecution now conjures Satan, Prince of Darkness, to the stand! *(Satan enters, waves amiably to the jury)* **(Pg 35-37)** So . . . Dark One, tell me: Did you ever have any conversations with Judas Iscariot prior to his selling-out of Jesus Christ?

SATAN: No, I did not.

P ATTORNEY: Never "entered into him" as I believe Saint Luke's Gospel puts it?

SATAN: No. Quite sure.

P ATTORNEY: Well, then, how 'bout after he did the deadly deed? Did you speak with the Savior Betrayer then?

SATAN: I spoke to him, yeah.

P ATTORNEY: Care to share?

SATAN: Not a problem. I appeared to Mr. Iscariot at a bar and grill shortly after the night in question.

(Scene Break)

SATAN: When I encountered Mr. Iscariot, he appeared to have already taken full advantage of the Happy Hour . . . . *(to Judas)* Oh. Hello, friend. How are you this evening?

JUDAS: *(obviously intoxicated)* "How am I this evening?" What are you, a maître d', man?

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SATAN: I'm Clementine. Clementine of Cappadocia.

JUDAS: Yeah?! Well why don't you go home Cappa-douche-a, okay?!

SATAN: Doe-sha -- Cappa-doe-sha.

JUDAS: Well lemme ask you something – Cappa-doucha-a – do I look like someone who [cares] where you're from? Leave me alone!

SATAN: I will. Thanks for the advice. *(Starts to leave)*

JUDAS: Hey!!!! . . . Where you going?!

SATAN: It seems you prefer to be alone.

JUDAS: Why would I prefer that?! What're you saying: I look like some kinda Lone Wolf? So, what's your name?

SATAN: . . . Clementine . . of Cappadocia . . . ?

JUDAS: I'm Judas, Judas Iscariot. You never heard of me?

SATAN: Nope.

JUDAS: You don't get around much, do ya? *(Beat)* **(Pg 38-39)** Hey man, If I told you something corny, would you think that I was, like a [jerk]?

SATAN: Not at all.

JUDAS: Okay . . . I'm kinda mildly afraid of going to hell.

SATAN: Why?

JUDAS: Minor incident last night – a miscalculation on my part – nothing serious.

SATAN: Well, one thing I can tell you about hell: As an eternal destination, it's apparently vastly underrated. Hell is nothing more than the absence of God, which, if you're looking for a good time, is not at all a bad thing.

JUDAS: Even if I did something, perhaps, a little controversial?

SATAN: Hey, I wouldn't worry about going to Hell. God understands.

JUDAS: Yeah, but, don't choices have, like consequences?

SATAN: C'mon, you really think we have a choice?

JUDAS: Okay, well, say, what if someone were to betray, for example . . . the Messiah –

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SATAN: -- You mean the Messiah, Messiah? Well, since you asked, I guess I'd say that this guy . . .

JUDAS: Cuz this is just some typo-theoretical guy here –

SATAN: Right. I'd say that if this clown we're talking about betrayed the Messiah, that probably, ***"It would've been better for that man if he had never been born."***

JUDAS: Never been born?!

SATAN: Hey . . . you asked.

(Scene Break) – *Courtroom where the defense attorney is cross-examining Satan.*

DEFENSE ATTORNEY: **(Pg 66-67)** Mr. Satan, you've had a long standing feud with God, correct?

SATAN: No. I love God.

D ATTORNEY: You love God? **(Pg 69-70)** Mr. Satan! What specifically do you love about God?

SATAN: I don't know where to begin.

D ATTORNEY: Pick a spot!

SATAN: I love God because He is all-powerful and all-forgiving. I love God because his justice is perfect. I love God because God loves me.

D ATTORNEY: God loves you?!

SATAN: Very much. Gift basket at Christmas – Hallmark greetings on all the major holidays.

D ATTORNEY: Mr. Satan – does God love Judas Iscariot? Yes or no?!

SATAN: Go love everybody.

D ATTORNEY: And yet Judas is in hell – so what use is God's love to Judas if my client is allowed to languish in damnation?

SATAN: Your client is free to leave whenever he wants to – in fact, I wish he would – I could use the room.

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D ATTORNEY: That's not true and you know it! -- The real truth is that God's love is conditional – isn't that right?! You failed to meet God's conditions, and he threw you in the trash! Judas failed – and he's in a catatonic stupor!

SATAN: Your client succumbed to despair –

D ATTORNEY: Yes! And if human despair is so powerful as to render God powerless over it, then, what does that say about God?! Either God's not all-powerful and therefore useless – or – God's love is conditional which renders that love false and unworthy! Which one is it? Is God powerless or spiteful – I am ordering you to answer!

SATAN: *(not unkindly)* You're powerless and spiteful – Not God. I'm truly sorry you feel that way.

D ATTORNEY: . . . Nothing further.

TRANSITION: Court is now dismissed

(Scene break)

(Scene opens on Judas in his own hell – he may be humming, singing, murmuring to himself, perhaps echoing the phrase "I am" aloud as Jesus speaks the next lines)

JESUS: **(Pg 70-73)** *(Makes his way toward Judas as he speaks to the audience)* Right now, **I am** in Fallujah. **I am** in Darfur. Right now, **I am** on Lafayette and Astor waiting to hit you up for change so I can get high. . . I was in that cave with Osama, and on that plane with Mohammed Atta . . . And what I need you to ***believe*** is that if you hate who I love that you do not know me at all. **I am** every last one. I love every last one. People ask of me: Where are you? I ask you: Where are you? *(to Judas)* Judas . . .

JUDAS: Who's that?

JESUS: Is it ever anybody else, Judas? *(Pause)* I miss you. *(Jesus lays a hand on him)*

JUDAS: DON'T TOUCH ME! Just, go away . . .

JESUS: I won't go away.

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JUDAS: Well, that'd be a first.

JESUS: I have never gone away, Judas . . . Look at me. *(Judas does)* I love you, Judas. And all I want – all I want – is to be not just near you – but WITH you. I'm right here, don't you see that?

JUDAS: You got a lot of nerve – I'll tell you what I know: I watched you trip over your own dusty feet to heal the sick, the blind, the lame, the unclean – But when I needed you – where were you, huh?!

JESUS: Judas . . .

JUDAS: You forgave Peter and Thomas – you raised Lazarus from the dead – But me? What about me?! You just, you just – I made a mistake! And if that was wrong, then you should have told me! And if a broken heart wasn't sufficient reason to hang, THEN YOU SHOULD HAVE TOLD ME THAT TOO!

JESUS: Don't you think . . . that if I knew that I would have changed your mind . . . that I would have? *(Beat)*

JUDAS: All I know is that you broke me – unfixable – and that I'm here . . .

JESUS: Judas – What if I were to tell you that you are not here? That you are with me in my kingdom even now, and that you have been there since the morning of my ascension and that you have never left? *(Judas spits in Jesus' face)*

JUDAS: That's what I think about you! *(Jesus doesn't wipe it off)*

JESUS: **(Pg 71)** I'm sorry. *(Pause)* Judas – If a thousand strangers spit on me, I will smile. But if the brother of my heart gives me a passing hard look, then, Judas – I will not sleep that night, nor sleep – at all – 'til he will let me love him again. **(Pg 73-74)** If you don't love me, Judas – then you're gonna have to look me in my eyes and say it.

JUDAS: I don't love you.

JESUS: If you don't love me, then why are you here?

JUDAS: Go!

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JESUS: Judas! . . . Judas, don't you know what would happen the very instant you got down on your knees?

JUDAS: Why on my knees? I've been on my knees my whole life! **You** left **me**.

JESUS: I never left you.

JUDAS: I would have never believed that you could have left. That you didn't love me.

JESUS: I do love you . . .

JUDAS: No! Why . . . didn't you make me good enough so you could have.

JESUS: Take my hands, Judas . . Please.

JUDAS: Where are they? I can't see them.

JESUS: They're right here. *(Jesus takes Judas' hand in his)*

JUDAS: Where are you going?! . . . . Don't leave me!

JESUS: I'm here.

JUDAS: I can't hurt . . .

JESUS: I love you, Judas . . .

JUDAS: I can't . . .

JESUS: Please love me, Judas.

JUDAS: I can't.

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AWARD HISTORY

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